



R. RAGU

Player to watch **NAHID RANA**

The 21-year-old Rana burst onto the scene in early 2024, earning a spot in Bangladesh's Test squad and immediately making an impact with his express pace. Consistently clocking over 140 km/h, and at times threatening to breach the 150 km/h mark, he quickly gained a reputation as a genuine fast bowler.

His standout performance came during Bangladesh's historic 2-0 Test series victory against Pakistan — in the second test in Rawalpindi where his four-wicket haul dismantled Pakistan's middle order. He has also troubled Indian batters on their home soil with his wobble-seam deliveries.

Rana's ability to hit hard lengths at pace has made him a difficult proposition for batters. His presence could be instrumental for Bangladesh in controlling the middle overs, forcing opponents into false shots and keeping the scoring rate in check.

stated that the priority was to include in-form batters capable of putting up high totals on flat wickets.

"It became difficult to have confidence in Litton when he failed to score runs in West Indies, where the rest of the batters managed to post big totals. We will be playing on good batting wickets in Rawalpindi. New Zealand lost there despite scoring 336, so we need top-order batters in form."

However, a closer look at the recent Bangladesh Premier League (BPL) suggests that Ashraf's concerns remain valid. Apart from Tanzid, who made 485 runs — the second-highest in the tournament — none of the batters demonstrated consistent form. The next-best performer, all-rounder Mehidy Hasan Miraz, managed 355 runs at an average of 27.30.

In Bangladesh's most recent ODI series, a 0-3 defeat to West Indies in December, Mahmudullah emerged as the team's top scorer. Without Shakib, much of the burden will fall on Mahmudullah and Mushfiquir Rahim to keep Bangladesh competitive. One bright spot is Jaker Ali, who has shown promise as a clean hitter. His unbeaten 62 off 57 balls in the third ODI against West Indies provided a glimpse of his ability. In five ODIs so far, Ali has scored 151 runs at an average of 50.33, striking at over 111.

The bowling unit will rely on familiar names — Mustafizur Rahman and Taskin Ahmed — alongside young pace sensation Nahid Rana, who impressed against West Indies with his ability to generate extra bounce and pace. Mustafizur's death-over expertise,

Taskin's new-ball skills, and Mehidy Hasan's off-spin will be crucial in Bangladesh's attempts to apply pressure on the opposition.

SQUAD

Nazmul Hossain Shanto (c), Soumya Sarkar, Tanzid Hasan, Tawhid Hridoy, Mushfiquir Rahim, MD Mahmud Ullah, Jaker Ali Anik, Mehidy Hasan Miraz, Rishad Hossain, Taskin Ahmed, Mustafizur Rahman, Parvez Hossain Emon, Nasum Ahmed, Tanzim Hasan Sakib, Nahid Rana